13 Ways to Screw Up Your College Interview

By Ian McWethy

(INTERVIEWER 1 is in his/her office. INTERVIEWER 2 enters, a worried look on his/her face.)

INTERVIEWER 2: **(Pg 75-76)** We are . . . short . . . by one student. One student!

INTERVIEWER 1: The dean really thinks one student is going to make a difference?

INTERVIEWER 2: He's convinced if we can get one more kid to enroll this year, all our financial problems will be solved.

INTERVIEWER 1: But we don't have any more interviews scheduled. When does he want our recommendation by?

INTERVIEWER 2: Today . . . Or we're fired. I think he still blames us for accepting that pyromaniac that burned down the science center.

INTERVIEWER 1: But he had an amazing essay! How were we to know? *(INTERVIEWER 2 shrugs. INTERVIEWER 1 shakes his head in disgust.)* Well, what are we going to do? We finished our interviews last week.

INTERVIEWER 2: Look through the wait listed files and start calling. If any of them can see us today, let's give them a shot.

INTERVIEWER 1: The wait list? Oh God.

INTERVIEWER 2: Hey, keep your head up. The wait listed kids aren't as bad as you think.

INTRODUCTION

13 . . . (no, make that 7) Ways to Screw Up Your College Interview by Ian McWethy

(Pg 80-81) *(INTERVIEWER 2 is making notes in a file when BRETT, dressed in a suit, talking on a cellphone, comes into the room and paces around.)*

BRETT: Okay, okay! I'm totally on it, I'm on it, trust me. I'm gonna push my five o'clock to six, my Tuesday to Friday, and flip another thing with a thing I got next month…

INTERVIEWER 2: Excuse me-

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BRETT: Yeah, yeah, yeah, hold on. *(To INTERVIEWER 2)* I'II be done in a few. We're gonna have a great convo, I can feel it. *(Back to the phone)* Okay chief, I gotta wrap this up. I'm pumped, we're gonna blow this out of the water and blow people's minds. Manana. *(He hangs up) (to Interviewer)* Appreciate your patience! You're an ace in the hole. Okay! Let's do this thing.

INTERVIEWER 2: You're Brett? You're thirty minutes late.

BRETT: I know, I know, I got caught up in conference call, a nightmare lunch meeting . . . and this girl I'm dating. . .blah blah blah . . . you know.

INTERVIEWER 2: Well, I have another prospective student . . .

BRETT: I know, I know, I've got a meet and greet in a fiver so let's just bulldoze through this thing, shall we? You know what? I'm gonna take the reigns here and skip the whole "you ask questions part." So here's me: I'm a self-motivator, I'm extremely competitive, and I'm the life of the party. I like your school's aggressive economic program and its Greek social scene. Gonna pledge Alpha-Phi-Beta, or Delta-Kai-Delta . . . depending on the pledge class. My stats are well above your average so let's make this happen. If you're in the boat, I'm driving the ship. We good? *(BRETT sticks his hand out for a fist bump. INTERVIEWER 2 doesn't respond. Not noticing, BRETT stands up and answers his phone.)* Whattup buttercup! Yeah, I just had to do this lame face-to-face, I'm on my way. Kidding me, nailed it! It's the Brettster you're talking about here.

*******Scene - INTERVIEWER 1 with LILY *******

(Pg 81-83) INTERVIEWER 1: Thanks again for coming in on such short notice.

LILY: Please, it was no trouble at all.

INTERVIEWER 1: So tell me about yourself. What subjects do you like in school, do you have any hobbies? You know stuff like that.

LILY: Hobbies? I have a few, I suppose. I used to be really into swimming but . . . I haven't . . . not since . . . that day . . . *(LILY simmers with emotion.)*

INTERVIEWER 1: Are you okay? We don't have to . . .

LILY: No, it's okay. . .I want to, I. . .I need to talk about it. It was a blistering summer day. it was one of the hottest days in recorded history. But swimming was my life. . . I went to the pool

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early, got on my swimming suit, and began my morning stretches. It was during my warm-ups that I saw him. . .a little boy, fiery red hair, freckles sprinkled across his pale white skin, teetering on the edge on the pool. Before I could even think to warn him, he tumbled into the watery abyss. His body thrashed about violently, his eyes closed shut from the sting of chlorine, his voice silenced from all the water he was swallowing. I jumped into the water and swam over as quickly as I could but . . .I was too late . . . he was . . . *(LILY is overcome with emotion.)* That was eight years ago and . . .I've never set foot in a pool since.

INTERVIEWER 1: Lily, that was very brave of you to share this with me. Witnessing a death like that. . .especially that of such a young child-

LILY: No, he didn't die. The lifeguard pulled him out of the water.

INTERVIEWER 1: Oh, well even seeing a near death experience-

LILY: He was only in the water a few seconds when the lifeguard pulled him out.

INTERVIEWER 1: I thought you said "it was too late"?

LILY: IT WAS TOO LATE FOR ME! I couldn't save him because . . .I was TOO . . .late . . . *(LILY is overcome with emotion)*

INTERVIEWER 1: *(confused)* So, you saw a kid fall into a pool who was almost immediately picked up by a lifeguard. This is the event that shaped your life and caused you so much emotional distress?

LILY: You weren't there! You don't know what it's like to actually . . . be there and . . . see it!

*******Scene - INTERVIEWER 2 with KELLY*******

INTERVIEWER 2: **(Pg 84-85)** Hi, you must be Kelly. *(Opening her file)* So, let's see here . . . oh! You know what, we never received your college essay.

KELLY: *(tightly wound, a Stepford wife-ish smile)* Is that right?!?

INTERVIEWER 2: Yeah, I'm not, uh, sure what happened. Do you have a copy of it?

KELLY: Oh absolutely. I've got it right here in my bag! *(She reaches into her bag, pulls out a single sheet of paper and hands it to the interviewer)*

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INTERVIEWER 2: That's great, thank you . . . so, uh . . .I'm sorry, this is your college essay? It's . . . this is a drawing of a girl. . .in a pink dress. *(A very awkward beat.)* Okay, well, let's look at your transcript shall we . . . *(opens Kelly's file and is speechless.)* You have no GPA?

KELLY: That's right.

INTERVIEWER 2: And you didn't take the SATs?

KELLY: Well now, how about that!

INTERVIEWER 2: According to this, you have a perfect attendance record, but have refused do any homework or take any tests. Kelly, I'm not even sure how you got to this point. You can't go to college without a GPA.

KELLY: Perhaps you'd like to see my recommendation. *(KELLY hands over another paper)*

INTERVIEWER 2: No, Kelly, I'm . . . there is no way any University, let alone ours, is going to- *(looks at the paper)* This is a picture of a cat . . . saying "meow."

KELLY: *(Correcting)* Me-ow. Yes. *(KELLY nods and gives a big "dead behind the eyes" smile.)*

INTERVIEWER 2: Well, thank you for coming, we'll be in touch.

KELLY: Alright then, you take care. *(KELLY doesn't leave)*

INTERVIEWER 2: Please leave, you're freaking me out. *(She doesn't – just a creepy smile)*

*******Scene - INTERVIEWER 1 with EVE*******

EVE: (Pg 86-87) *(EVE belts out the end to "Defying Gravity" from "Wicked.")* NOTHING'S GONNA BRING. . ..ME. . .. . .DOOOOOWWWWWN! *(Beat)*

INTERVIEWER 1: *(covering his/her horror and shock)* Wow, well you are obviously very talented, but . . . again, and I can't stress this enough, this IS NOT the audition for the theatre program so . . . a monologue and two songs really aren't-

EVE: *(In full "Music Man" performance mode)* TROUBLE, OH WE GOT TROUBLE, / RIGHT HERE IN RIVER CITY! / WITH A CAPITAL "T" / THAT RHYMES WITH "P" / AND THAT STANDS FOR POOL. . .

*******Scene - INTERVIEWER 2 with ELIZABETH*******

INTERVIEWER 2: (Pg 87-88) Well your grades, recommendations all look pretty good. Is there anything else you can tell me about yourself? Something that's maybe not on the page.

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ELIZABETH: Yeah, let's see . . .I never played sports in school but I've played in a number of rec leagues. Volleyball, soccer, basketball. I volunteer at a soup kitchen every month, I'm a practicing vampire, and I teach sailing during the summer at a sleep away camp. Is that what you were looking for?

INTERVIEWER 2: Yeah, definitely, um. . .I'm sorry… it sounded like you said you were a "practicing vampire."

ELIZABETH: Oh. Yes. Pretty much my whole life.

INTERVIEWER 2: Okay. So. . .you think you're a vampire?

ELIZABETH: Oh, no, no, no. I'm a ***practicing*** vampire. It's completely different. Basically, I live my life in preparation for the day when I will, hopefully, turn into a vampire. So, I sleep in a coffin, avoid garlic, eat lots of bloody meat, chew with my fangs . . . all in the hopes that one day, if I'm diligent enough . . .I will turn into a vampire.

INTERVIEWER 2: I see, uh . . . well then, uh, what are you doing here now? I mean, you shouldn't be out during the day, right?

ELIZABETH: That's a common stereotype. Vampires, just like humans, can walk freely in daylight without receiving even the slightest irritation to the skin.

INTERVIEWER 2: Elizabeth! You're not going to turn into a vampire. There's no such thing as vampires!

ELIZABETH: *(extremely insulted)* Wow! That may be the most offensive thing I've ever heard. Honestly, I expected more out of this university. *(she storms out)*

*******Scene - INTERVIEWER 1 with JASON*******

JASON: **(Pg 91)** *(in a cape and top hat, he pulls a card out of the deck)* So then is THIS your card?

INTERVIEWER 1: No.

JASON: But where there's a diamond, there must be a . . . Jack of all trades. . .in clubs.

INTERVIEWER 1: Still not my card.

JASON: Darn it. I was practicing all week.

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INTERVIEWER 1: Look, I'm very glad you have hobbies outside of school, but maybe we can get back to-

JASON: Oh, sure, sure, sure. After . . . you show me the card UNDERNEATH YOUR SEAT.

INTERVIEWER 1: *(looks under his/her seat and picks up a playing card)* "Rules on how to Play Texas Hold 'em?"

JASON: And who makes the rules, but a KING.

INTERVIEWER 1: Hey, that's actually my card.

JASON: Really?

INTERVIEWER 1: No.

JASON: Okay, okay . . . let's try this. Pick a number between one and five thousand. NO, wait, first tell me your favorite color, then pick a number.

*******Scene – INTERVIEWERS CONSULT*******

INTERVIEWER 1: **(Pg 92-93)** *(defeated)* Not one?

INTERVIEWER 2: Not a single . . . one.

INTERVIEWER 1: This is bad.

INTERVIEWER 2: This is . . . extremely bad.

INTERVIEWER 1: You must have been too critical. I'm sure you saw at least one kid we could recommend.

INTERVIEWER 2: Hey, if you want to look through my files, be my guest. *(INTERVIEWER 1 looks through INTERVIEWER 2's files.)*

INTERVIEWER 2: Well, if you're gonna look at mine, then I'm gonna look at yours. *(They read in silence for a bit.)*

INTERVIEWER 1: What does "practicing vampire" mean? *(INTERVIEWER 2 closes the file for him/her and shakes his/her head "no." They continue to look.) (A knock on the door. EMILY comes in.)*

EMILY: Hi, my name's Emily Court. . .I have an appointment at 5?

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INTERVIEWER 1: Oh my Gosh, right. Sorry, I. . . got a little sidetracked. *(finds her file and as he/she looks at it a look of relief appears on his/her face)* Emily, so . . . wow, nice record. Valedictorian of your class?

INTERVIEWER 2: I'm also really impressed with the variety of after school programs you've amassed. First chair cellist, president of the student council, member of the thespians, and treasurer for something called the "relief club."

EMILY: It was a club formed by me and three friends as a public outreach . . . we do shelter meals, food drives, build houses . . . there wasn't really anything like that at our school. *(INTERVIEWER 1 and INTERVIEWER 2 look at each other in glee. Finally.)*

INTERVIEWER 1: Well, Emily, we should tell you that. . .

EMILY: *(EMILY's phone rings. EMILY scrambles to answer it.)* I'm so sorry. I never leave my phone on normally it's just . . . *(She looks at the number)* . . . this is my mom, I told her not to call unless it was really, really, urgent- I'm so sorry. I'll be quick. *(Answering her phone)* Hello? Yeah, no it's going fine. Any news? OH MY GOD! I GOT IN! I AM OFFICIALLY AN IVY LEAGUER! AAAAAHHHHH!!! *(EMILY dances around, ecstatic.)* And what about the Scholarship . . . ? . . . Are you kidding me! ARE YOU . . . but they hardly give out any money let alone a free ride! OH MY GOD! MOM! I'm gonna cry! *(To the Interviewers)* I'm sorry, I just have to . . . thank you, sorry . . . *(EMILY leaves the room, screaming, jumping, etc.) (The two INTERVIEWERS sit for a moment, deflated.)* (*INTERVIEWER 1 looks through a file sadly.)*

INTERVIEWER 1: This guy does magic.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Ian McWethy
Book: Random Acts of Comedy: 15 Hit One-Act Plays for Student Actors, Pgs 75-93
ISBN: 978-0981909974
Publisher: Playscripts, Inc.
Date (Month/Year): Aug 2011

AWARD HISTORY

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